

Coming of Age Under Trump

The Effect of First Electoral Exposure in a Trump Election on Long-Term Support Liberal Democratic Norms

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How do early political experiences during moments of democratic strain shape long-term attitudes toward liberal democracy? This paper investigates whether beginning one's political life in the context of the 2016 Trump election—marked by norm-breaking rhetoric, institutional conflict, and sustained challenges to liberal democratic norms—affects subsequent support for liberal democratic principles. Drawing on theories of political socialization, elite cue-taking, and partisan asymmetric sensitivity, I hypothesize that first-time voters in 2016 will exhibit weaker liberal democratic commitments than those who first voted in 2012, with effects concentrated among partisans and, within partisans, stronger among Republicans. Using a sharp regression discontinuity design (RDD) that leverages the age-based cutoff for voting eligibility, I compare Americans whose first eligible presidential election was 2012 to those whose first eligible election was 2016, using data from the 2020 American National Election Studies (ANES). The outcome is a composite Liberalism Index constructed from seven ANES items measuring support for free press, checks and balances, rule of law, and related liberal norms. Contrary to all three hypotheses, I find no statistically significant discontinuity in liberal attitudes at the eligibility threshold—neither in the full sample nor across any partisan subgroup. These null results are robust to alternative bandwidths, placebo cutoffs, and polynomial degree specifications. I discuss the implications of these findings for theories of political socialization and democratic backsliding, and outline promising avenues for future research.

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1 Introduction

The 2016 U.S. presidential election marked a rupture in American political life. Supporters chanted “Lock her up!” as protesters were forcibly removed from rallies, while journalists, judges, and opponents were routinely framed as enemies of the people (Bekafigo et al. 2019). For many young voters, this was their first political memory as adults; the moment they entered democracy. If early political experiences leave lasting marks, what are the consequences of coming of age in a context where core democratic principles were openly challenged? This gives rise to the following research question

Does entering political life during an election characterized by weaker adherence to liberal democratic norms shape long-term support for these norms?

To address this question, I use a sharp regression discontinuity design (RDD) to leverage the age-based cutoff for voting eligibility in the 2012 U.S. presidential elections. This enables me to isolate the causal effect of entering the electorate during a moment of democratic stability versus democratic rupture.

1.1 2016 Toxicity and the Trump Effect

The 2016 U.S. presidential election was far from ordinary, marking a rupture, both in tone and behavior, that distinguished it sharply from previous elections. By many accounts, the 2016 race was “one of the most polarizing elections in U.S. history” (Bekafigo et al. 2019, 1174). Trump’s candidacy was marked by unprecedented negative campaigning, intra- and inter-party conflict, and rhetoric targeting entire social groups. Cassese (2021, 30) documents that “dehumanizing political rhetoric was a common facet of the 2016 presidential contest,” contributing to a broader climate of political hostility. Cremer (2023) argues that the Republican Party’s platform under Trump—combining anti-immigrant nativism, anti-elite populism, and authoritarian rhetoric—closely matches the definition of the populist radical right studied in the European context.

From a legal and institutional standpoint, Trump represented a break from previous presidencies: as early as 2016, he was openly undermining unwritten conventions that helped uphold liberal democracy. He consistently disrespected political norms, merged private gain with public office, ignored transparency norms, and normalized falsehoods (Siegel 2018). His attacks on the media framed news organizations as enemies of the people (Meeks 2020), while contempt for judicial independence represented a direct challenge to the liberal component of American democracy. Kaufman and Haggard (2019) argue that Trump’s rise bears resemblance to democratic backsliding patterns observed in Venezuela, Hungary, and Turkey, characterized by demonization of the media, racial scapegoating, attacks on judicial independence, and erosion of democratic norms. It is in this environment that a cohort of young voters entered the electorate for the first time.

1.2 Literature Review

This thesis draws on three strands of literature to examine how coming of age under a norm-breaking presidency may shape support for liberal democratic principles. The first establishes the conceptual foundations, defining liberal democratic norms and their relationship to democratic backsliding. The second examines public support

for democratic norms: why it matters for democratic survival, how it has evolved across time and cohorts, and what explains variation in citizens’ willingness to uphold these norms. The third explores early adulthood as a formative period for political socialization, focusing on the long-term effects of first-time electoral experiences.

1.2.1 (Liberal) Democracy

Existing research highlights a distinction between ‘electoral’ and ‘liberal’ democracy (Claassen et al. 2025; Coppedge et al. 2016; Mounk 2018). Whereas the former is akin to a ‘bare-bones’ democracy closely mirroring Dahl’s “polyarchy” (Dahl 1971), the latter refers to a political system that extends beyond free and fair elections, encapsulating “the intrinsic value of protecting individual and minority rights against potential ‘tyranny of the majority’ and state repression more generally” (Coppedge et al. 2016, 582). This is achieved through a robust rule of law, checks on executive power, and the protection of civil liberties (Claassen et al. 2025; Coppedge et al. 2016).

Claassen et al. (2025) differentiate between two categories of liberal democratic principles. Whereas electoral democracy encompasses only electoral principles—freedom of expression, freedom of association, universal suffrage, elected decision-makers, and free and fair elections—liberal democracy additionally incorporates liberal principles: judicial and legislative constraints on the executive, and equality before the law. Crucially, systems that lack these liberal principles can be understood as forms of “illiberal democracy,” a variety that “mixes a substantial degree of democracy with a substantial degree of illiberalism” (Zakaria 1997, 24), and which is closely related to populism (Mudde 2004, 2007).

1.2.2 Support for Democratic Norms

Public support for liberal democratic norms constitutes the first of the two main strands of literature I examine. In this section, I discuss (i) the importance of this support for democratic survival, (ii) recent trends, and (iii) the main explanatory factors behind changes in support for liberal democratic norms—particularly elite cues and partisanship.

1.2.2.1 Importance and Recent Trends

Existing work underscores the importance of public support for liberal democratic norms for resilience against backsliding (Claassen 2020; Jacob 2025; Miller 2021; Weingast 1997). Weingast (1997)’s game-theoretic model frames democracy as a self-enforcing equilibrium: sovereigns respect democratic limits only insofar as citizens are willing to defend those limits. This mechanism breaks down when citizens hold inconsistent views about where those limits lie, or when they are unwilling to enforce them. Claassen (2020) provides the most comprehensive empirical evidence, finding a robust positive link between public support and the survival of democratic institutions across 135 countries and almost 30 years. Jacob (2025) extends this by proposing that anti-pluralist incumbents are more likely to violate democratic norms when public support for democracy is low, as doing so carries lower electoral costs.

Against this backdrop, existing trends in the United States present a mixed but alarming picture. Foa and Mounk (2016) document the “deconsolidation” of democratic support, particularly among younger cohorts: whereas 72% of Americans born before World War II viewed living in a democracy as essential, only 30% of millennials did. Claassen and Magalhães (2023) similarly find generational rather than life-cycle declines: younger cohorts are consistently less supportive of democracy, and these lower levels do not appear to increase with age. Wuttke, Gavras, and Schoen (2022) document analogous trends across 18 European countries, where growing shares of respondents—particularly younger cohorts—hold “democrats in name only” positions (Wuttke, Gavras, and Schoen 2022, 416). Not all accounts point uniformly downward: Treisman (2023) cautions against overstating democratic erosion and argues that support has been rising in established Western liberal democracies, while Holliday et al. (2024) find that the American public remains overwhelmingly supportive of democratic norms even after divisive elite rhetoric—though crucially, this support does not translate into willingness to punish norm-violating candidates electorally. Together, these findings paint a mixed yet unsettling picture: even if aggregate levels of democratic support remain high, the behavioral implications of that support are deteriorating, particularly among younger cohorts.

1.2.2.2 Some Explanations

A growing body of research has sought to explain variation in citizens’ willingness to support or tolerate democratic norm violations, identifying a range of supply- and demand-side factors.

On the supply side, Grillo and Prato (2023) shows that a leader can gain popularity by violating democratic norms less severely than expected—a “fear-and-relief” mechanism through which lowered expectations make milder transgressions come as a relative relief. Frederiksen (2022) similarly finds that competence and undemocratic behavior operate in parallel: a competent but undemocratic candidate may be preferred over a democratic but incompetent one.

On the demand side, Grossman et al. (2022) argue for the existence of “majoritarian” voters—individuals who believe that popular election grants leaders a blank check, including to undermine checks and balances. Bartels (2020) find that the strongest predictor of endorsing democratic norm violations among Republicans is ethnic antagonism. Krishnarajan (2023) introduces the concept of “rationalizing democracy”: citizens resolve the tension between co-partisan advantage and democratic principles by redefining the terms, coming to view desired policies pursued through undemocratic means as democratic. A related body of work identifies misperceptions as a key mediating mechanism: Braley et al. (2023) show that willingness to undermine democratic norms is driven partly by the belief that opponents are already willing to subvert democracy first, and that correcting these perceptions made partisans more willing to uphold democratic norms.

1.2.2.3 Polarization

Before turning to the main explanatory trends, I consider the role of affective polarization, the “tendency [...] to view opposing partisans negatively and copartisans positively” (Iyengar and Westwood 2015). Polarization in the United States has increased significantly in recent decades, making its relationship with democratic norm

erosion particularly salient (Boxell, Gentzkow, and Shapiro 2024; Iyengar et al. 2019; Phillips 2022). However, this relationship remains “far from straightforward” (Druckman, Green, and Iyengar 2023, 150).

Theoretically, as polarization increases hostility between partisan groups, voters may become more willing to accept anti-democratic measures directed at the out-group. Orhan (2022) provides observational support across 53 countries and 170 elections, finding that affective polarization is positively correlated with democratic backsliding. Kingzette et al. (2021) show that affective polarization leads to lower public support for democratic norms through “norm politicization”: under high polarization, partisans will opportunistically oppose or support liberal protections depending on whether their party holds power. However, empirical evidence remains inconclusive: Broockman, Kalla, and Westwood (2023) and Voelkel et al. (2023) find that experimentally reducing affective polarization does not translate into increased support for democratic norms, and Druckman, Green, and Iyengar (2023) concludes that affective polarization does not appear to be a necessary condition for democratic backsliding.

These mixed findings motivate the turn to the two explanatory frameworks that have accumulated stronger empirical support: elite cues and partisan dynamics.

1.2.2.4 Elite Cues and Partisanship: The Main Trends

Existing literature converges on two interconnected explanations for why citizens fail to consistently uphold democratic norms: the influence of elite cues, which shape what citizens perceive as acceptable, and the dynamics of partisanship, which determine how those cues are received.

Elite Cues

Voters rely extensively on cues from political figures to navigate their political environment (Archer 2023; Brader and Tucker 2012; Dickson and Hobolt 2025). Bakker, Lelkes, and Malka (2020) show that this reliance on partisan cues reflects the “expressive utility” of following one’s party: cue receptivity is highest among citizens with strong partisan social identification. These mechanisms have direct implications for democratic norm erosion. Druckman (2024) places elites at the center of backsliding dynamics: they are uniquely positioned to violate laws and norms, and citizens function as latent legitimators whose tolerance for undemocratic actions encourages further transgression. The empirical evidence is substantial: Clayton et al. (2021) show that exposure to Trump’s attacks on the legitimacy of the 2020 election eroded electoral confidence among his supporters; Arceneaux and Truex (2023) document that belief in the “big lie” was pervasive and sticky among Republicans; and Fossati, Muhtadi, and Warburton (2022) demonstrate that Indonesians are more willing to embrace illiberal practices when endorsed by in-party elites.

Partisanship

Partisanship operates in tandem with elite cues. M. H. Graham and Svolik (2020) find that most American voters prioritize partisan considerations over democratic principles when the two conflict—“partisans first and democrats only second” (M. H. Graham and Svolik 2020, 393). Simonovits, McCoy, and Littvay (2022) document widespread “democratic hypocrisy”: citizens systematically apply different standards to democratic norms

depending on whether their party holds power. Svolik (2020) illustrates how partisanship can undermine citizens' capacity to function as a democratic check: when punishing norm-violating candidates requires voting against one's party, most voters opt for partisan loyalty over democratic principle.

Taken together, the interaction of elite signaling and partisan identity creates conditions under which even abstractly pro-democratic citizens may come to tolerate or endorse norm violations, particularly when exposed to a political context characterized by sustained elite questioning of democratic principles. Whether first exposure to such a context during a politically formative stage of adulthood produces durable effects on democratic commitments is the central empirical question of this thesis.

1.2.3 Coming of Age

The final strand of literature examines the role of early adulthood as a moment of political socialization. Existing research suggests that first electoral experiences during early adulthood play a formative role in shaping long-term political behavior.

1.2.3.1 Childhood and Early Adulthood as Formative Periods for Long-Term Behavior

Existing research has underscored the enduring impact of childhood and early adulthood on later-life outcomes. Shonkoff et al. (2012) detail how toxic stress in early childhood leads to long-term impairments in learning, emotional regulation, and health. Bellucci, Fuochi, and Conzo (2020) show that individuals exposed to warfare during childhood exhibit lower financial risk-taking in adulthood, and Kesternich et al. (2020) find that childhood hunger in postwar Germany is associated with significantly lower interpersonal trust later in life.

While childhood sets important trajectories, early adulthood provides a second period of heightened malleability. Arnett (2000) conceptualizes this period of "emerging adulthood" as uniquely open-ended: between ages 18 and 25, individuals explore work, education, relationships, and lifestyle choices with relative freedom from institutional and familial constraint, making this an intense phase of self-construction. Luecken and Gress (2010) argue that early adulthood marks a second point of vulnerability and openness to external influence, in which childhood dispositions can be reinforced, redirected, or disrupted. This developmental plasticity means that external shocks or exposures during this period may have durable effects on future behavior.

1.2.3.2 Early Adulthood and Future Political Behavior

One of the domains in which the long-term impact of early adulthood is most evident is political behavior. Mannheim (1928) introduces the concept of 'fresh contact,' arguing that initial encounters with political authority and conflict crystallize lasting political worldviews. Recent empirical work supports this: Neundorff, Smets, and García-Albacete (2013) show that political interest develops most dynamically during adolescence and early adulthood, stabilizing around age 25, while Dinas (2013) finds that young adults adjust their political evaluations more flexibly than older cohorts.

Ghitza, Gelman, and Auerbach (2023) find that political preferences are largely shaped by events encountered between ages 14 and 24, and that cohort-defining moments like the Kennedy, Reagan, or Trump years create

stable partisan divides. Sears and Valentino (1997) find that exposure to presidential campaigns can shape attitudes even before eligibility to vote, and argue that generational cohorts “polarize internally around the symbolic events of its day” (Sears and Valentino 1997, 47)—a finding directly relevant to understanding the 2016 election as a cohort-defining moment.

Longitudinal data confirm that political orientations established in this period often endure. Jennings and Niemi (2014), drawing on decades of panel data, find that attitudes formed in early adulthood tend to persist across the life course. Sears and Funk (1999) similarly show that party identification and ideological orientations exhibit striking stability over nearly four decades.

1.2.3.3 First-Time Voting and Habit Formation

One of the clearest applications of the formative nature of early adulthood lies in first-time voting. Plutzer (2002)’s developmental theory of turnout conceptualizes young adulthood as a period in which individuals either transition into habitual voting or remain habitual nonvoters, with initial experiences proving especially consequential. Dinas (2012) finds that voting in a first election increases the likelihood of voting in subsequent elections, even decades later. Meredith (2009), using age-based discontinuities, shows that eligibility at a presidential election increases turnout in subsequent elections and affects partisan identification, with effects persisting across cycles.

This study extends the logic of first-election effects beyond turnout and into attitudes toward democratic norms. While prior research shows that early voting can entrench civic habits, it remains unclear whether the *nature* of the political context—particularly in moments of institutional erosion—shapes how young people internalize liberal democratic attitudes.

Taken together, this literature positions early adulthood as a formative and fragile window, where social contexts and political experience leave lasting marks on civic behavior. This thesis contributes to this literature by examining whether coming of age during a period marked by democratic norm erosion shapes long-term attitudes toward liberal democratic principles.

1.2.4 Conclusion

Existing research underscores the developmental importance of early adulthood, the long-term effects of first-time voting, and the role of elite signaling and partisan dynamics in shaping democratic attitudes. It also documents both the importance of public support for democratic survival and the conditions under which that support erodes. While these strands are often studied separately, they intersect in moments of political rupture. This thesis builds on their insights by asking whether coming of age during a period marked by democratic norm violations produced lasting effects on democratic commitments. By connecting theories of political socialization with empirical findings on the drivers of support for liberal democratic norms, it contributes to understanding how democratic backsliding may be reproduced across generations through the socialization of new voters.

2 Theory

Building on these insights, this section introduces the paper’s theoretical framework. It outlines how early political socialization, partisan sensitivity, and the ideologically asymmetric effects of political context shape long-term liberal attitudes.

2.1 H1: First Encounters with Democracy in a Moment of Rupture

Early adulthood is politically formative: experiences during this period leave long-lasting marks on political behavior. This paper applies that logic to the 2016 presidential election. For many voters born around the turn of the millennium, their first experience of democracy as political adults was voting in 2016—a context where long-standing norms around pluralism and institutional respect were openly put into question by political elites like Donald Trump (Sides, Tesler, and Vavreck 2018; Siegel 2018).

If this context is norm-eroding rather than norm-affirming, the process of political learning becomes distorted at the moment it is most sticky (Franklin 2004; Dinas 2012). First-time voters in 2016 were especially vulnerable: not only because they were politically young, but because the institutional cues they received were normatively degraded. This leads to the central hypothesis:

H1: Being a first-time voter in the 2016 election will have a negative effect on long-term liberal attitudes (‘first-time sensitivity’ hypothesis)

2.2 H2: Partisan Sensitivity to Political Context

A growing body of research suggests that partisanship shapes how individuals interpret and respond to their political environment. Mandel and Omorogbe (2014) find that partisans report higher life satisfaction under favorable political conditions and lower satisfaction under unfavorable ones, while independents express intermediate levels—suggesting that partisans are more emotionally attuned to political developments. Independents also vote at significantly lower rates than partisans (Magleby, Nelson, and Westlye 2011) and are less influenced by partisan cues (Brader and Tucker 2012; Banda 2021; Fuller, Cerda, and Rametta 2025), suggesting lower overall political engagement and a weaker tendency to internalize affective frames from polarized political contexts.

As a result, independents may have been less susceptible to the norm-violating cues of the 2016 Trump campaign, while partisans may have absorbed these cues more readily. This ‘sensitivity asymmetry’ leads to the expectation that the long-term impact of coming of age in 2016 will be more pronounced among partisans than among independents:

H2: The negative effect of being a first-time voter in the 2016 election will be stronger among partisans (Republicans or Democrats) than among independents (‘non-partisan insensitivity’ hypothesis)

2.3 H3: Asymmetric Sensitivity and Partisan Differences

The third hypothesis builds on the “asymmetric sensitivity” hypothesis proposed by Mandel and Omorogbe (2014), which posits that Republicans are more psychologically and affectively responsive to their political environment than Democrats. This pattern is consistent with research showing that conservatives are more likely to attend to and be affected by affectively charged or threatening information (Carraro, Castelli, and Macchiella 2011; Dodd et al. 2012; Oxley et al. 2008), anticipate and experience stronger emotional reactions to negative outcomes (Joel, Burton, and Plaks 2014), and are more easily disgusted (Inbar, and Bloom 2009; Smith et al. 2011). J. Graham, Nosek, and Haidt (2012) further argue that conservatives process political information with greater attentiveness to both ingroup and outgroup cues.

In the context of 2016, this implies that Republican first-time voters may have been more deeply affected by the politicized context—and more likely to internalize norm-violating cues as acceptable, particularly if doing so aligned with partisan goals. This interpretation is supported by Gidengil, Stolle, and Bergeron-Boutin (2022), who show that Republicans were more likely to support in-party candidates favoring executive aggrandizement when they echoed cues from President Trump. Crucially, the norm-eroding elite cues came primarily from the Republican side (Cassese 2021; Siegel 2018), further amplifying the expected asymmetry:

H3: Within partisans, the negative effect of being a first-time voter in the 2016 election will be stronger among Republicans than among Democrats (‘asymmetric sensitivity’ hypothesis)

3 Research Design

This study uses a sharp RDD to identify the long-term causal impact of being first eligible to vote during a ‘conventional’ versus ‘unconventional’ political environment on citizens’ liberal attitudes. The core idea is that young people who were just old enough to vote in the 2012 U.S. presidential election experienced a fundamentally different initial political environment than those who were just too young and first voted in 2016. This design translates into a cutoff at age 26 in 2020 (the year of the survey): respondents aged 26 or older were just old enough to vote in 2012, while those under 26 were not. Within a narrow bandwidth around this threshold, the treatment—first voting in 2016 rather than 2012—is as-good-as-randomly assigned by birth timing.

The RDD is estimated using the following specification:

$$Y_i = \alpha + \tau D_i + f(X_i) + \varepsilon_i$$

Where:

- Y_i is the outcome, a continuous index measuring liberal attitudes.
- D_i is an indicator equal to 1 if respondent i was ineligible to vote in 2012 (i.e., under 26 in 2020; first voted in 2016), and 0 otherwise.¹

¹Only bias-corrected estimates are presented in the main text. The conventional and bias-corrected with robust standard errors estimates are shown in the robustness section and discussed further in the Appendix.

- τ is the parameter of interest, capturing the local average treatment effect (LATE) of first voting in 2016 rather than 2012. A negative τ is consistent with the first-time sensitivity hypothesis (H1).
- X_i is the running variable, defined as `years_from_cutoff` = 26 – age, normalised so that the cutoff falls at $c = 0$. Positive values correspond to respondents younger than 26 (ineligible in 2012; treatment = 1); negative values correspond to respondents aged 26 or older (eligible in 2012; treatment = 0).
- $f(X_i)$ denotes a flexible function (e.g., first- or second-order polynomial) of the running variable estimated separately on each side of the cutoff.
- ε_i is an error term.

3.1 Data

The analysis draws on the 2020 American National Election Studies (ANES) cross-sectional survey, which provides a large, nationally representative sample with a broad set of items on democratic attitudes.²

3.2 Liberal Democracy Index

To capture individual-level support for liberal principles, I constructed a composite index from seven items in the 2020 ANES: support for a free press, belief in the importance of checks and balances, endorsement of the rule of law, the belief that citizens must agree on facts to sustain democracy, resistance to unitary executive power, concern over the freedom of the media, and the principle that journalists should have access to government officials. I first z-score standardised each item, then assessed internal consistency (Cronbach’s = 0.78), confirming that the items capture a coherent underlying construct. I then used principal axis factor analysis to extract a single latent factor, and rescaled the resulting scores to a 0–1 range, producing a continuous liberalism index where higher values indicate stronger normative commitment to liberal democratic norms.³

3.3 Analysis

I estimated a series of sharp RD models using local polynomial regression, implemented via `rdrobust` in Python. Each model uses local linear estimation (polynomial order = 1) and MSE-optimal bandwidth selection, with the running variable `years_from_cutoff` centred at $c = 0$. The preferred estimate throughout is the bias-corrected specification with robust standard errors. Models are run separately for each subgroup to test the three hypotheses:

- **Entire sample (H1):** To test the *first-time sensitivity* hypothesis, I estimated the RD on the full 2020 sample.
- **Partisans vs. Independents (H2):** To test the *non-partisan insensitivity* hypothesis, I split the sample into partisans (self-identified Democrats and Republicans, with leaners coded to their respective parties) and independents.

²The full set of items is presented in the appendix.

³For further details on index construction, refer to the Appendix.

- **Republicans vs. Democrats (H3):** To test the *asymmetric sensitivity* hypothesis, I ran separate models for Republicans and Democrats.

For the full sample and each of the four subgroups, I estimated two specifications: one without covariates, and one including education, income, and race (as dummy variables, with White as the omitted baseline) as controls—selected on the basis of covariate balance tests indicating significant imbalance across the treatment and control groups.

To assess the robustness of the main estimates, I conducted three sets of sensitivity checks, reported in full in the Appendix: bandwidth sensitivity (re-estimating models across a range of bandwidths from 30% to 200% of the MSE-optimal value), placebo cutoffs (re-running the RDD at ± 1 , ± 2 , and ± 3 years from the true cutoff), and polynomial degree sensitivity (re-estimating with first-, second-, and third-order polynomials). All robustness checks are run with and without controls.

4 Results

This section presents the findings of the paper. I begin by visualizing the discontinuity near the age-26 threshold for the full sample and the partisan subgroups, then present the RD estimates organized by hypothesis, and finally assess their robustness.⁴

4.1 Regression Discontinuities

Figure 4.1 plots the liberalism index against respondents’ approximate age at the time of the 2012 election ($\text{age_in_2012} = \text{age} - 8$), with the dashed vertical line marking the cutoff at age 18. Points to the right of the cutoff were old enough to have voted in 2012 (control group); points to the left were not yet 18 in 2012 and first voted in 2016 (treatment group). A negative τ would therefore indicate that 2016 first-time voters score lower on the liberalism index than their 2012 counterparts, consistent with H1.

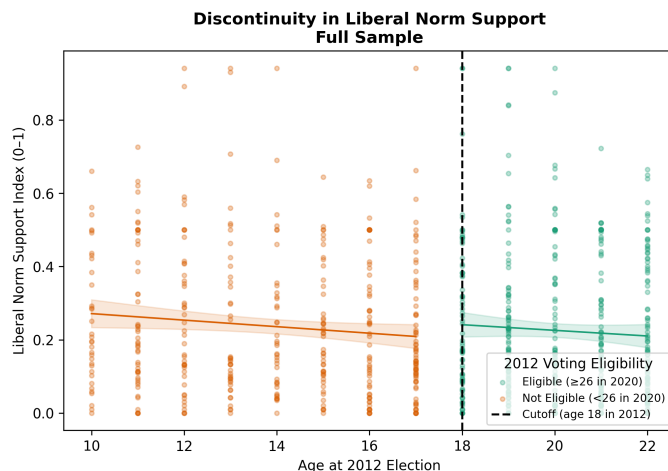


Figure 4.1: Discontinuity in Liberal Attitudes at the Cutoff (Full Sample)

⁴Only bias-corrected estimates are presented in the main text. The conventional and bias-corrected with robust standard errors estimates are shown in the robustness section and discussed further in the Appendix.

There is no visually apparent discontinuity at the threshold for the full sample. The confidence intervals on both sides of the cutoff overlap substantially, and the fitted lines run smoothly through the threshold without any clear jump. Figure 4.2 breaks this down by partisanship subgroup.

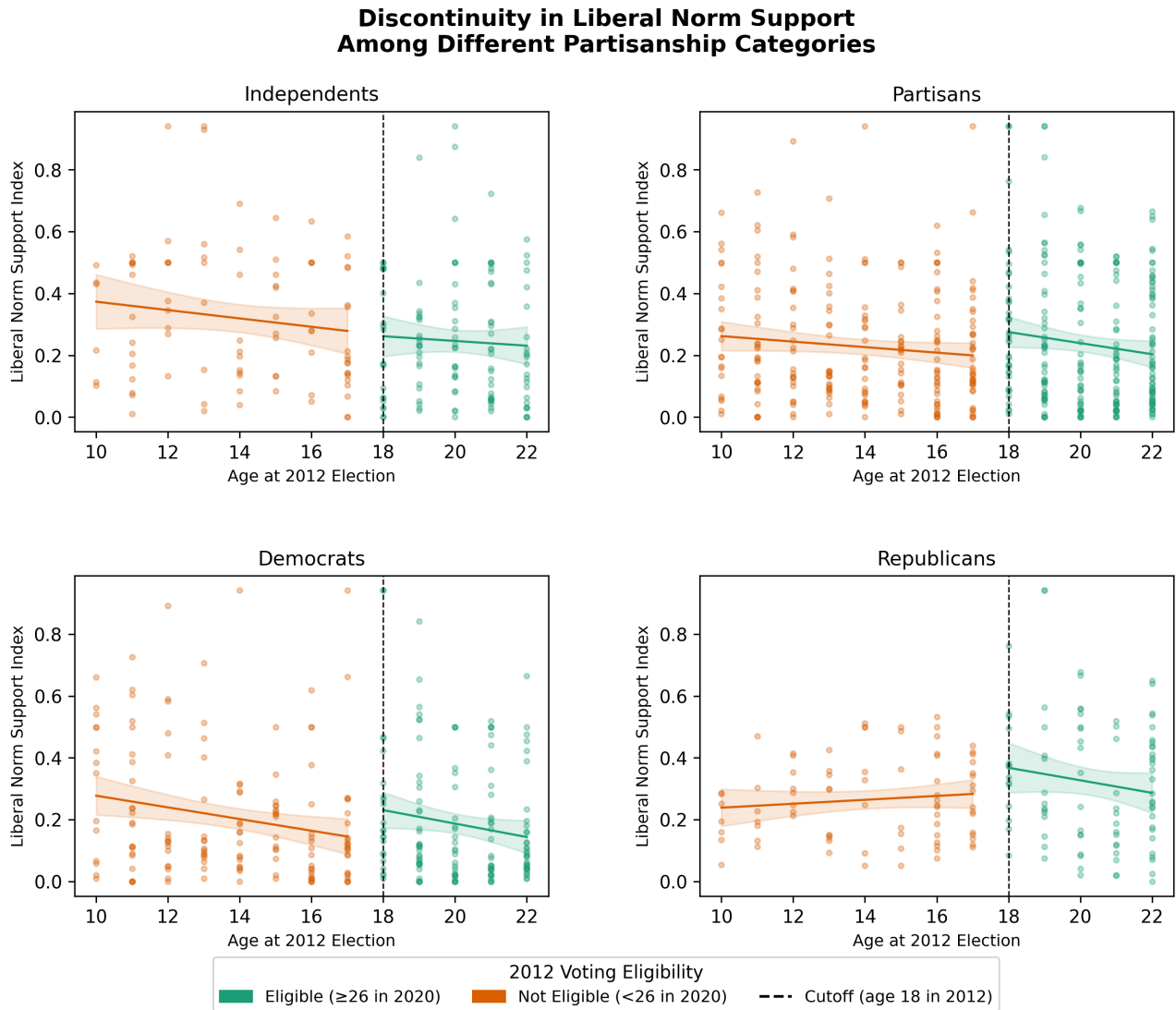


Figure 4.2: Discontinuity in Liberal Attitudes at the Age-18 Cutoff (Partisanship Subgroups)

The same pattern holds across all subgroups. Whether examining independents, partisans, Democrats, or Republicans separately, no visually compelling discontinuity is apparent at the threshold. In all panels, the confidence intervals on both sides of the cutoff overlap, consistent with a null result.

4.2 RD Results

Figure 4.3 presents the estimated treatment effects (τ) from the bias-corrected local linear RD models, with and without controls, for each sample. All estimates are expressed on a 0–1 scale.

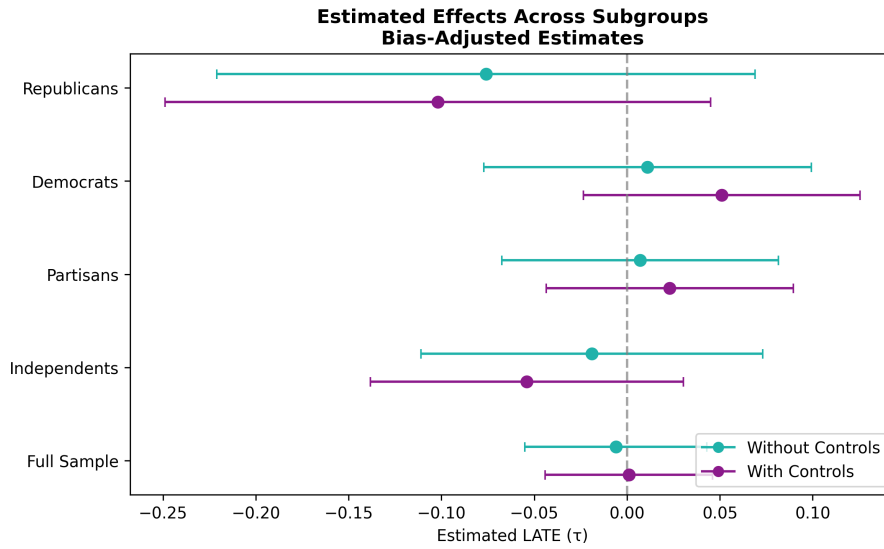


Figure 4.3: Points represent the bias-corrected estimate of τ at the cutoff, with horizontal lines indicating 95% confidence intervals. A negative τ indicates that 2016 first-time voters score lower on the liberalism index than 2012 first-time voters, consistent with H1. Separate estimates are shown for the full sample and partisan subgroups, with and without controls for education, income, and race.

4.2.1 H1: First-Time Sensitivity

For the full sample, the estimated discontinuity is small and statistically insignificant in both the uncontrolled and controlled models. There is no detectable causal effect of first-time voting eligibility timing on liberal attitude scores at the threshold. The data therefore provide no support for H1: coming of age during the 2016 Trump election does not appear to produce measurably weaker liberal commitments relative to those who first voted in 2012.

4.2.2 H2: Non-Partisan Insensitivity

Among independents, τ is small and statistically insignificant, consistent with the expectation of H2 that politically unaffiliated individuals would be less sensitive to the political context of their democratic initiation. Among partisans, the estimate is likewise insignificant, offering no evidence that partisan identifiers were more affected by first-vote timing than the full sample. H2 therefore finds no empirical support in these data.

4.2.3 H3: Asymmetric Sensitivity

Separating partisans by party, the estimates for both Democrats and Republicans are statistically insignificant across both specifications. No asymmetric effect is detectable: Republican first-time voters do not differ meaningfully from their slightly older counterparts in their liberal attitude scores, nor do Democrats. H3 is not supported.

4.3 Robustness Checks

Given that the main estimates are null across all subgroups, the robustness checks serve primarily to confirm stability rather than to qualify significant findings. Figure 4.4 presents the three estimate types side by side.

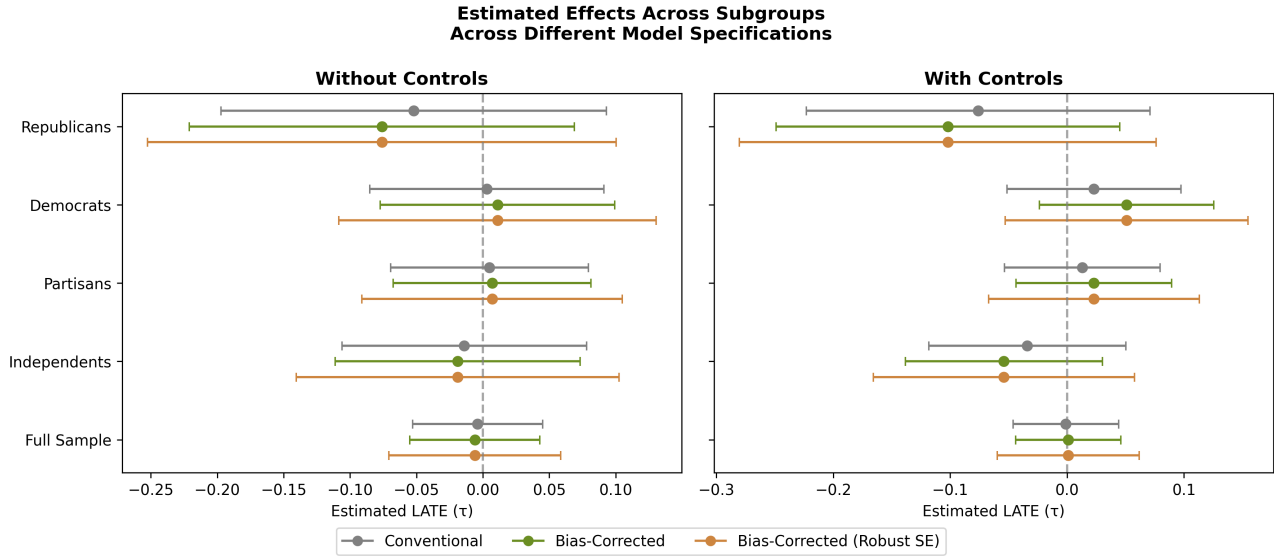


Figure 4.4: Comparison of Estimate Types — Conventional, Bias-Corrected, and Bias-Corrected with Robust Standard Errors — across subgroups and model specifications.

The null result is consistent across all three estimate types for every subgroup, with and without controls. Figure 4.5 presents the bandwidth sensitivity, placebo cutoff, and polynomial degree checks for the full Democrat subgroup, as an illustrative case.⁵

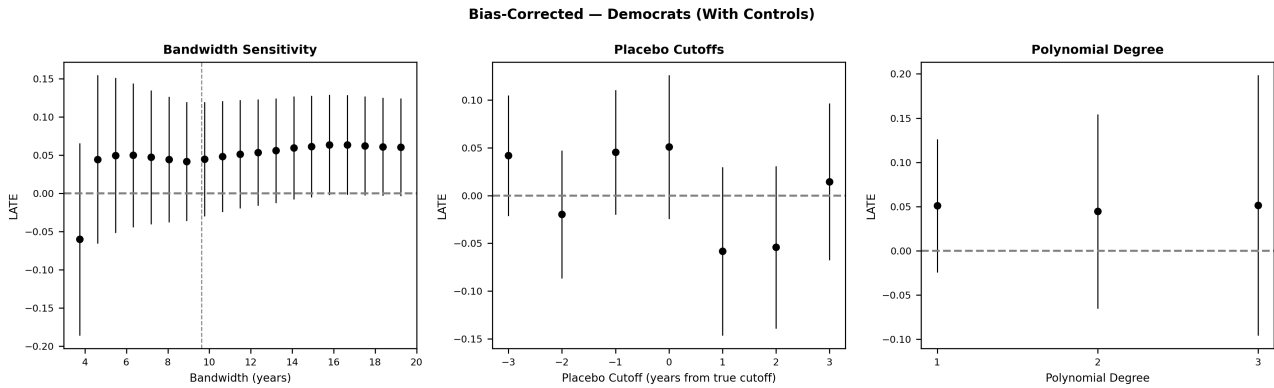


Figure 4.5: Robustness Checks: Bandwidth Sensitivity, Placebo Cutoffs, and Polynomial Degree (Democrats)

Estimates remain consistently null across a wide range of bandwidths. Placebo cutoffs at ± 1 , ± 2 , and ± 3 years from the true threshold similarly yield insignificant results, suggesting that the null finding at the true cutoff is not an artifact of the specific threshold chosen. Results are also stable across polynomial degrees. Taken together, the robustness checks reinforce the conclusion that there is no detectable effect of first-vote timing on liberal democratic attitudes in this sample.

⁵Robustness checks for the remaining subgroups are presented in the Appendix.

5 Conclusion

This paper set out to ask whether coming of age during the 2016 Trump election produced measurably weaker liberal democratic commitments. Using a sharp RDD that compares those just eligible to vote in 2012 to those who first voted in 2016, I find no statistically significant discontinuity in liberal attitudes—neither in the full sample nor across any partisan subgroup. These null results are stable across alternative bandwidths, placebo cutoffs, and polynomial specifications. Taken together, they suggest that political socialization during a period of elite norm violation does not automatically translate into weaker liberal commitments among those just entering the electorate.

These findings are notable in their own right. One possible interpretation is that liberal democratic norms are more durable and resistant to short-term contextual shocks than theories of impressionable-years socialization might imply. Another is that the mechanism connecting first-time voting context to democratic attitudes is more complex, conditional, or delayed than the simple exposure hypothesis tested here captures, perhaps requiring sustained exposure over multiple electoral cycles rather than a single formative election.

Several avenues for future research follow directly from these limitations. First, the present design relies on age measured in years in the 2020 ANES, which introduces a non-trivial measurement margin around the true eligibility cutoff. Future work using exact birth dates (available in restricted-access versions of the ANES) would sharpen the discontinuity considerably, potentially uncovering effects that are obscured by the coarseness of the current running variable. Second, the sample of first-time 2016 voters in the 2020 ANES is small relative to the full sample, limiting statistical power. Replication using the 2024 ANES, or pooling across multiple survey waves, could improve precision while also enabling an examination of whether the effects might change due to exposure to the polarized contexts of the 2020 and 2024 presidential elections. Third, future research could examine whether the null results are specific to the liberal norms dimension, or whether they extend to electoral norms and attitudes toward democratic institutions more broadly.

Finally, the interaction between political socialization and partisan power status deserves closer attention: research on democratic hypocrisy suggests that citizens apply different standards to democratic norms depending on whether their party holds power (Simonovits, McCoy, and Littvay 2022; M. H. Graham and Svobik 2020). Young voters who came of age in 2016 experienced a Republican win whereas those who first voted in 2020 experienced a contested Democratic win. Whether the socialization effect differs depending on which party is in power at the moment of political initiation, and how this interacts with the respondent’s own partisan identity, is a theoretically rich question that warrants further study.

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6 Appendix

6.1 Index Construction

This appendix documents the construction of the Liberalism Index, including item wording, internal consistency, factor structure, and rescaling. The index is based on seven items measuring support for liberal democratic norms.

6.1.1 Item Wordings

The table below provides the exact question wording for each of the seven items included in the index.

Table 6.1: Liberal Items and Survey Wording

Item	Survey Question
Free Press	How important is it that news organizations are free to criticize political leaders?
Checks and Balances	How important is it that the executive, legislative, and judicial branches of government keep one another from having too much power?
Rule of Law	How important is it that elected officials face serious consequences if they engage in misconduct?
Agree on Facts	How important is it that people agree on basic facts even if they disagree politically?
Unitary Executive	Would it be helpful, harmful, or neither helpful nor harmful if U.S. presidents could work on the country's problems without paying attention to what Congress and the courts say? How helpful/harmful?
Journalist Access	Do you favor, oppose, or neither favor nor oppose elected officials restricting journalists' access to information about government decision-making?
Media Undermined Concern	How concerned are you that some people in the government today might want to undermine the news media's ability to serve as a check on governmental power?

6.1.2 Internal Consistency

To evaluate the internal reliability of the seven survey items, I computed Cronbach's alpha. The raw alpha is 0.741 and the standardized alpha is 0.782, indicating acceptable internal consistency. The table below reports the factor loadings, communalities, uniquenesses, and item-total correlations for each item from the principal axis factor solution.

Table 6.2: Factor Diagnostics for the Liberalism Index

Item	Loading	Communality	Uniqueness	Item-Total r
Free Press	-0.722	0.522	0.478	0.579
Checks and Balances	-0.749	0.561	0.439	0.541
Rule of Law	-0.694	0.482	0.518	0.475
Agree on Facts	-0.643	0.414	0.586	0.423
Unitary Executive	-0.541	0.293	0.707	0.412
Journalist Access	-0.608	0.369	0.631	0.496
Media Undermined Concern	-0.643	0.413	0.587	0.509

6.1.3 Factor Structure

I used principal axis factoring (no rotation) to assess whether the seven items capture a single underlying construct. The table below reports the eigenvalues, variance explained, and cumulative variance for each factor.

Table 6.3: Eigenvalues from Principal Axis Factoring

Factor	Eigenvalue	Variance Explained	Cumulative Variance
1	3.054	43.6%	43.6%
2	1.112	15.9%	59.5%
3	0.781	11.2%	70.7%
4	0.575	8.2%	78.9%
5	0.546	7.8%	86.7%
6	0.542	7.7%	94.4%
7	0.389	5.6%	100.0%

Based on the Kaiser criterion (eigenvalue > 1) and the scree plot below, a single factor was retained. The first factor accounts for 43.6% of the total variance; the second factor's eigenvalue of 1.112 falls just above the Kaiser threshold but is substantially smaller than the first, and the scree plot shows a clear elbow after the first factor. All factor loadings are negative and range from -0.541 to -0.749 , confirming that the items load coherently on a single liberal democratic norms dimension (higher scores = stronger liberal norm support after sign reversal at the rescaling stage).

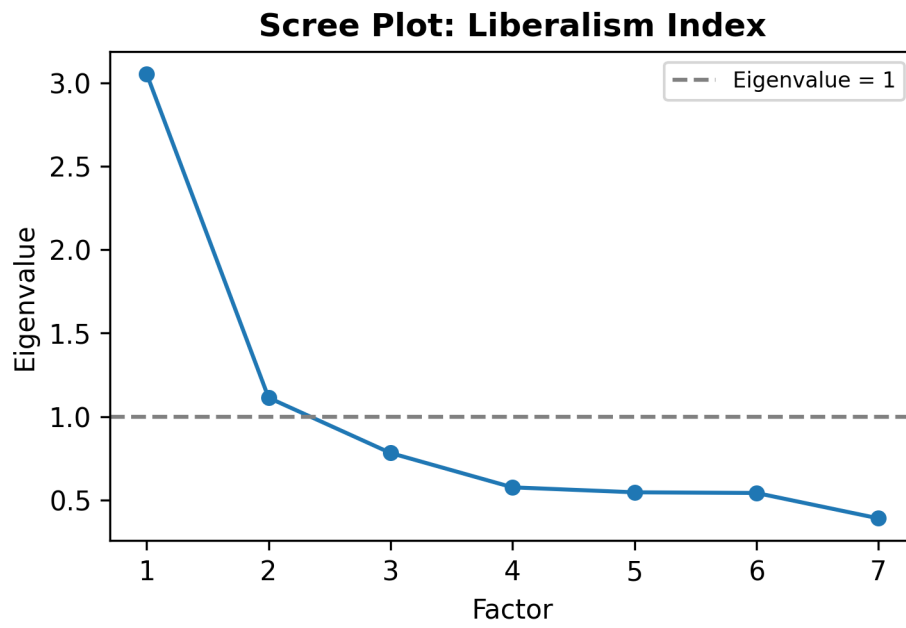


Figure 6.1: Scree Plot: Eigenvalues for the Liberalism Index

6.1.4 Index Rescaling

Factor scores on the first factor were extracted and rescaled to the unit interval $[0, 1]$ using min-max normalization. Higher values indicate stronger endorsement of liberal democratic norms. This transformation does not affect the relative positioning of respondents on the latent trait. The resulting index has a mean of 0.205 and a standard deviation of 0.169, with a range from 0 to 1 across 5,324 non-missing respondents.

6.2 RD Results

The coefficient plot below presents all three estimate types — conventional, bias-corrected, and bias-corrected with robust standard errors — side by side for each subgroup and model specification.

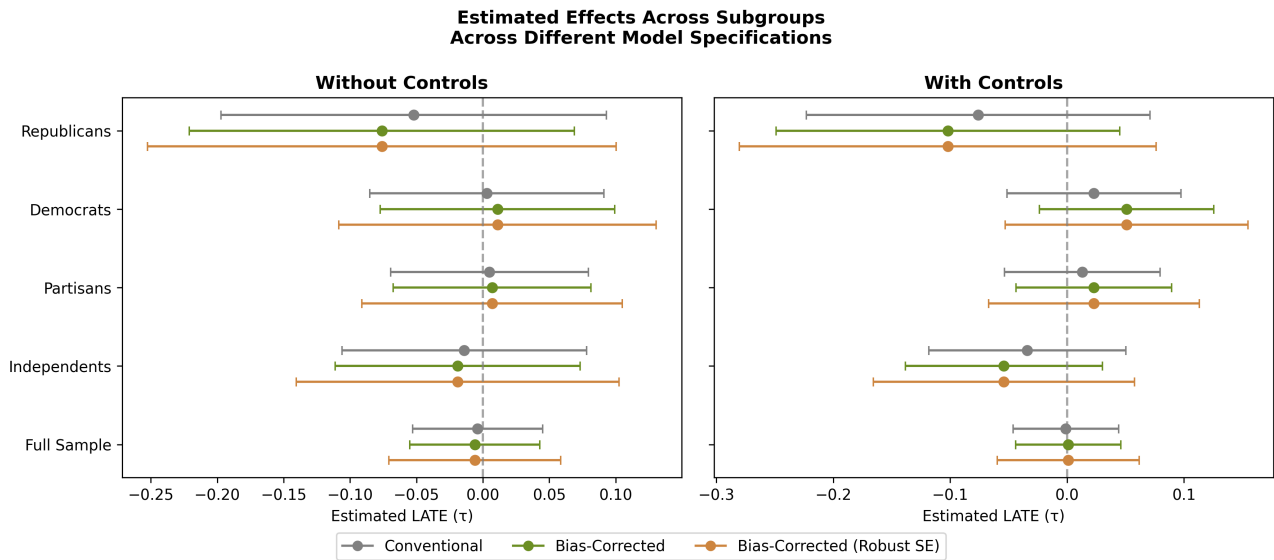


Figure 6.2: Comparison of all three RD estimate types — conventional, bias-corrected, and bias-corrected with robust standard errors — for the full sample and all partisan subgroups, with and without controls.

6.3 Robustness Checks

The following figures present the full set of robustness checks — bandwidth sensitivity, placebo cutoffs, and polynomial degree — for each subgroup. All plots show bias-corrected estimates with controls. With the exception of some odd ‘jumps’ in statistical significance in very low bandwidths, and under some placebo cutoffs, the robustness checks confirm the lack of statistical significance of the previous findings.

6.3.1 Full Sample

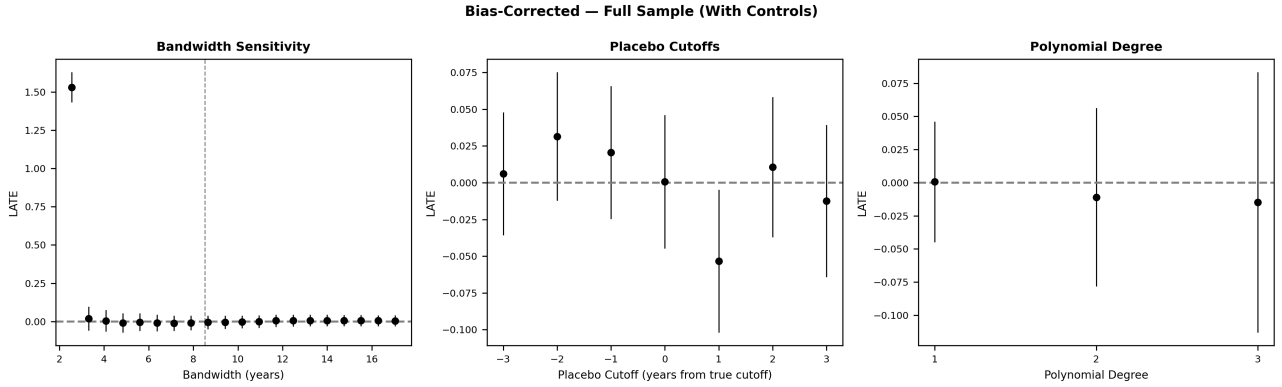


Figure 6.3: Robustness Checks: Bandwidth Sensitivity, Placebo Cutoffs, Polynomial Degree (Full Sample)

6.3.2 Independents

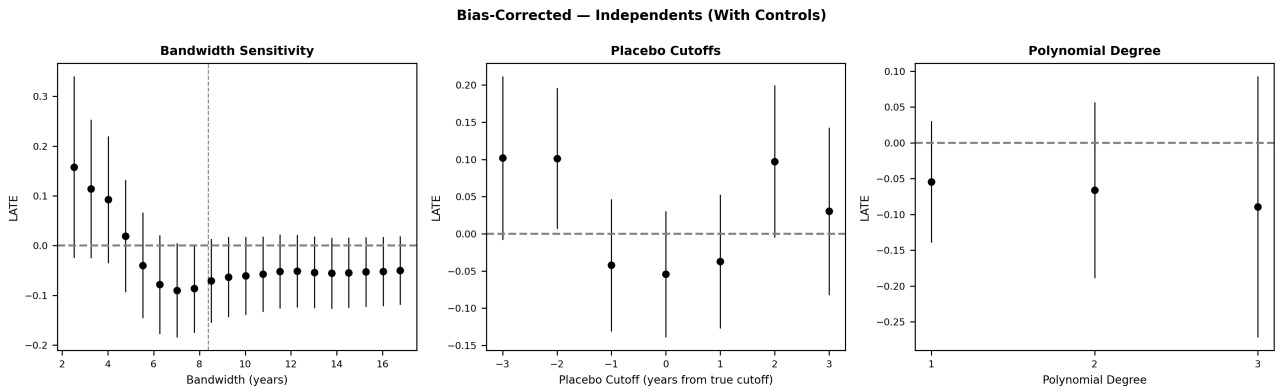


Figure 6.4: Robustness Checks: Bandwidth Sensitivity, Placebo Cutoffs, Polynomial Degree (Independents)

6.3.3 Partisans

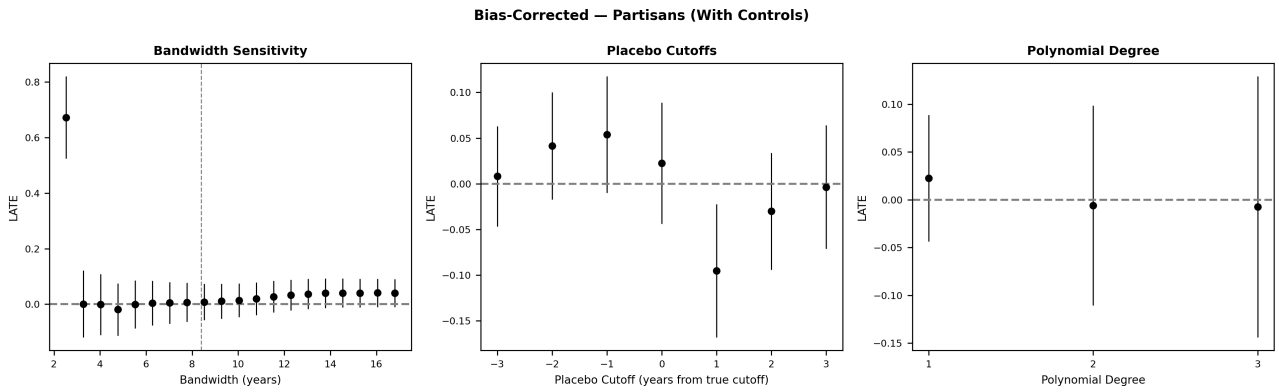


Figure 6.5: Robustness Checks: Bandwidth Sensitivity, Placebo Cutoffs, Polynomial Degree (Partisans)

6.3.4 Democrats

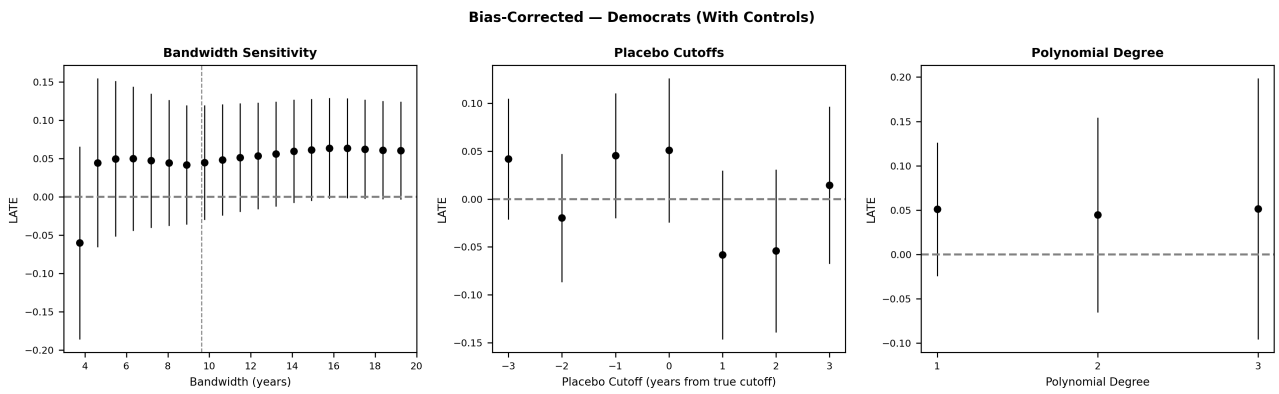


Figure 6.6: Robustness Checks: Bandwidth Sensitivity, Placebo Cutoffs, Polynomial Degree (Democrats)

6.3.5 Republicans

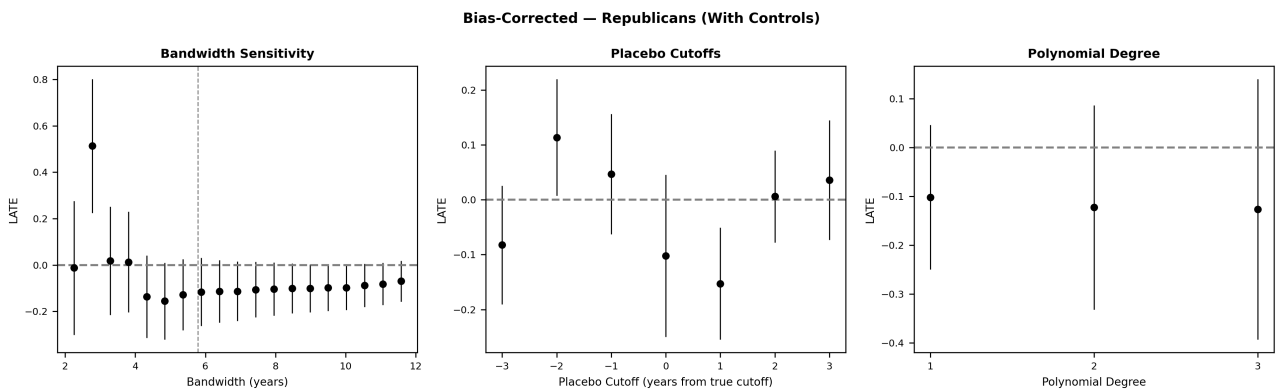


Figure 6.7: Robustness Checks: Bandwidth Sensitivity, Placebo Cutoffs, Polynomial Degree (Republicans)